

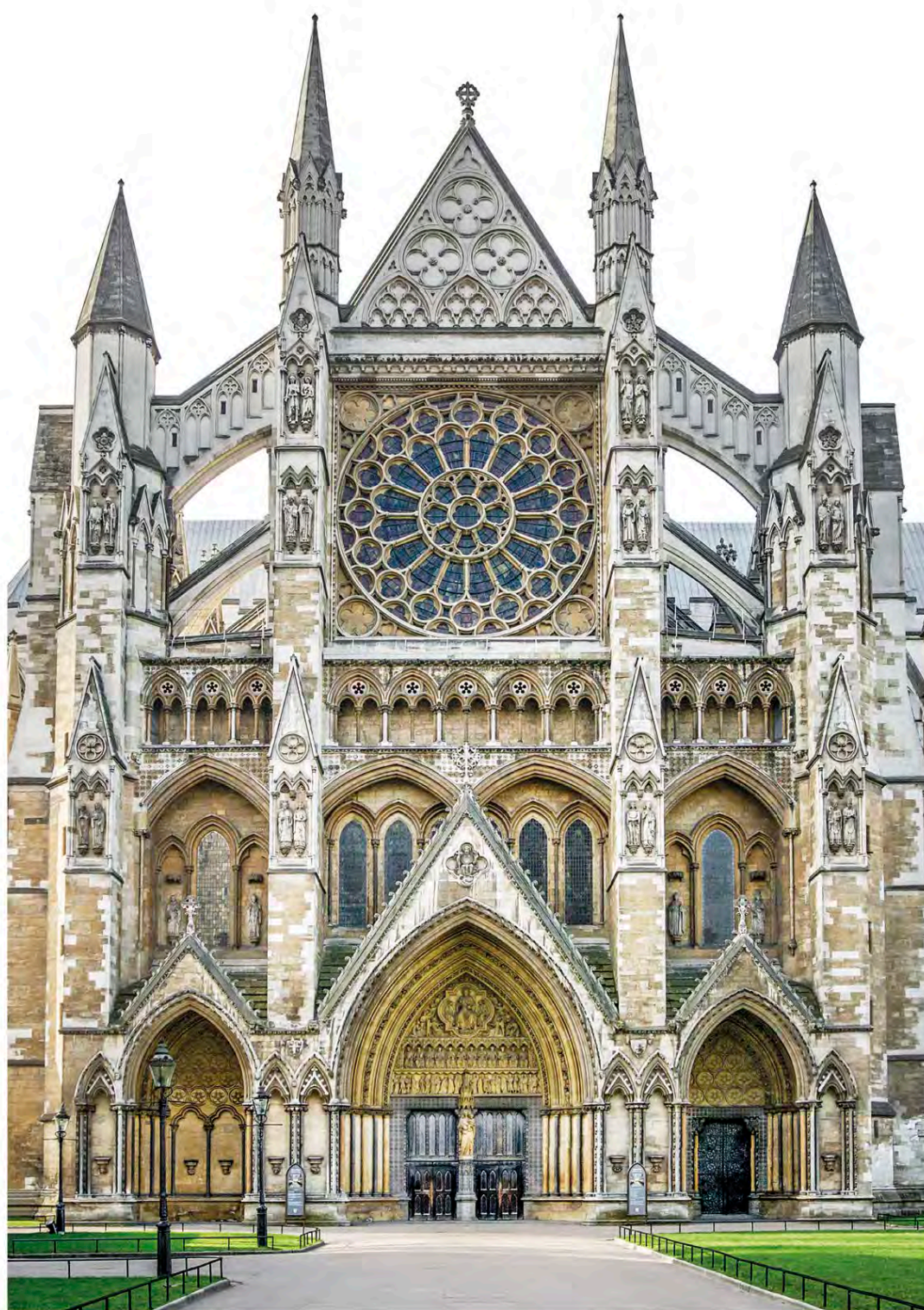
Westminster Abbey

A Gothic masterpiece, 900-year-old coronation church of the British monarchy, and mausoleum of Britain's kings and national heroes



▽ EMERGING STYLE

The facade of Westminster's north transept includes typical Gothic pointed arches and carved portals. The rose window reflects French influence, although the narrow, pointed "lancet" windows also signal the emergence of an English style.



Founded by King Edward the Confessor in around 1042, Westminster Abbey has witnessed the coronation of all but two of England's monarchs (Edward V and Edward VIII) since William the Conqueror (r.1066–1087), as well as 16 royal weddings. In 1245, Edward's Norman Romanesque church—the first of its kind in England—was demolished to make way for King Henry III's new Gothic cathedral. Over the centuries, more chapels, including Henry VII's spectacular Lady Chapel, were added, and the abbey's massive west towers, designed by Nicholas Hawksmoor, were completed in 1745.

National treasures

Spreading over an area of more than 105,000 square ft (9,750 square m), the abbey is architecturally exquisite and also home to an extraordinary collection of memorial sculptures and medieval wall paintings. Around 3,300 people are buried in the abbey, and many more memorialized. British monarchs from Edward the Confessor to George II lie alongside some of Britain's most notable personages, including Charles Darwin and Isaac Newton, and those—like Jane Austen, William Shakespeare, and Charles Dickens—commemorated in Poet's Corner.

The abbey is a **"Royal Peculiar,"** subject only to the **Sovereign**

WESTMINSTER'S TRIFORIUM

Many Gothic cathedrals had a passageway or gallery above the side aisles, known as a triforium. Overlooking the abbey floor 52 ft (16 m) below, the triforium provided excellent views of Elizabeth II's coronation in 1953 but was long used as a storage space. In 2018, Westminster's eastern triforium was opened to the public as a gallery for the abbey's treasures.

